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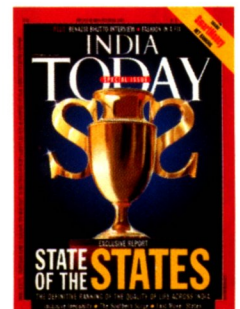
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Our annual State of the States survey, now in its sixth year, is as accurate a progress report on governance as any document from the Planning Commission. It is based on a model devised by two of the country's leading economists supplemented with additional reportage from our state correspondents. Our report essentially tracks a state government's performance across a range of key parameters like infrastructure, health, agriculture, investment, education and consumer markets covering all 30 states and five Union territories.

In an environment of economic change and new challenges, the 2008 report reflects the reality of economic reforms: imbalanced growth. The rise of Himachal Pradesh, for instance, proves that sustained reform delivers results while Kerala's slide shows how much of a barrier frequent strikes are to investment. The continuation of Punjab as the best state also indicates that a combination of agriculture and industrial growth delivers prosperity.

Each year the survey looks at a special theme. In previous years we looked at the post-reforms decade, district level development and last year, we reviewed the Government's claims of inclusive growth and poverty reduction. This year with elections looming, our package focuses on the state of parliamentary constituencies. We look at the state of VIP constituencies represented by cabinet ministers and chief ministers. Our findings reveal that much depends on the progress made by the state where the Lok Sabha seat is located. MPs from the consistently performing states like Punjab and Kerala derive benefits of good governance and growth. This also applies to MPs who represent constituencies in major metros. More important, it reveals that electing iconic or powerful MPs does little for the constituency. Barring one, not a single prime ministerial constituency ranks in the top 100 and a majority of the ministerial constituencies rank below the halfway mark.

Taken together, the study of states and the constituencies reveal the true face of India—how fast the country is changing, where it is changing, the leaders and the laggards and the new priorities and challenges confronting our chief ministers. As Managing Editor Shankkar Aiyar, who put together the cover package, says, "Our ratings simply reflect that reforms pay and bureaucratic sloth sinks the state." Our annual exercise has been an occasion for the states to compare their performance across the board with that of other states. This time our report hits closer to home, in the constituencies that the chief ministers represent. Our findings should come as a revelation to them and we hope, for the sake of their political future and of their constituents, that they heed the message the survey is sending out.



Our Sept 2007 cover

(Aroon Purie)